Multi Site Manager: AEM Sites vs Edge Delivery Services

Comparison for the WKND (edsmsm) project

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1. Summary

"MSM in Edge Delivery Services" can mean two different things, depending on where the content is authored:

Option	Authoring	Multi-site engine
A. AEM authoring + Edge Delivery	AEM Sites as a Cloud Service with the Universal Editor	Classic **AEM MSM** (blueprints, live copies, rollout configurations). Each live copy is published as its own Edge Delivery site
B. Document Authoring (Experience Workspace) + Edge Delivery	Document Authoring (da.live), now part of Experience Workspace	**Experience Workspace MSM**: base and satellite sites with page-level inheritance, set up through configuration sheets

Edge Delivery itself only delivers content. Reuse, inheritance and synchronization happen in the authoring layer. In both options, all sites can share **one code repository** ("repoless" multi-site).

In short: AEM MSM is a mature, highly configurable system. It works down to individual components and properties, with rollout configurations and Java extensions. Experience Workspace MSM is a lightweight, no-code model: whole pages either inherit from the base site or are detached, and syncing is a merge or replace.

This project is authored in Document Authoring, so **option B** applies today. The draft pages `msm-test` ("Version 3 from edsmsm") and `msm-test-page` ("From base") suggest Experience Workspace MSM is already being tried out.

2. Concept mapping

AEM MSM	Experience Workspace MSM	Notes
Blueprint (source)	**Base site**	The base is a whole site (repository); a blueprint is a content path
Live copy	**Satellite site**	A satellite is a separate site that inherits from the base
Nested live copy	Multi-level hierarchy	A site can be a satellite of one site and the base of another
Blueprint configuration	`msm` tab in the org config (`base`, `satellite`, `title` columns)	No code
Rollout configuration (trigger + actions)	No equivalent	Authors choose **Merge** or **Replace** when syncing
Rollout (push from source)	Base site pushes preview/publish to satellites, optionally cascading to descendants	
Synchronize (pull into a live copy)	Satellite **Get / Sync** content from the base	
Cancel inheritance (component)	**Detach** (whole page)	Experience Workspace inheritance is per page, not per component
Re-enable inheritance	**Reconnect**	Reconnect deletes the local copy
Reset	Sync with **Replace**	Both discard local changes
Suspend / Resume	No equivalent	Detach, then reconnect later
Detach (permanent)	Detach (reversible with Reconnect)	
Exclusions (properties, node types, paragraphs)	No equivalent	

AEM MSM	Experience Workspace MSM	Notes
Live Copy Overview	MSM app and Prepare menu actions	
Language copy + translation project	**Translate app** (Translate / Copy / Rollout / Skip per language)	

3. Detailed comparison

Area	AEM MSM (option A)	Experience Workspace MSM (option B)
Inheritance model	Copy-based: every live copy page physically exists and is kept in sync	Resolution-based: a page that doesn't exist on the satellite is read from the base at preview/publish time. A page that exists on the satellite is detached
Smallest unit	Component and property	Page (document)
Scope of a relationship	Any page or branch, shallow or deep	Whole site (base ↔ satellite)
When sync happens	Rollout triggers: On Rollout, On Modification, On Activation, On Deactivation	Author actions only (preview/publish push, Get/Sync); no triggers documented
What sync does	Ordered sync actions: update, copy, delete, references, order, version, activate, workflow, read-only	**Merge** (three-way structural merge keeping satellite edits where possible) or **Replace**
Link rewriting	`referencesUpdate` rewrites internal links to the live copy	No automatic rewriting documented; use relative links and site-relative paths
Configuration	Code in `/apps` (rollout and blueprint configs) and OSGi; deployed via Cloud Manager	Config sheets in the browser: org `msm` tab, `prepare` / `apps` tabs, content provider setting
Extensibility	Java API and custom sync actions	Apps and plugins in Experience Workspace; no sync-action API
Content types	Pages, Content Fragments, Assets, Experience Fragments (varies by version)	Pages (documents), with referenced fragments handled by the Translate app
Translation	Translation framework and translation projects; connectors	Translate app: Google Translate built in; Lionbridge, Smartling, Trados or a custom connector
Publishing to Edge Delivery	Each live copy root is mapped to its own Edge Delivery site (`public.json` path mapping, content source `bin/franklin.delivery`)	Each base or satellite is its own Edge Delivery site; base authors can push preview/publish to satellites
Monitoring	Live Copy Overview console, Blueprint and Live Copy page property tabs	MSM app; detached vs inherited is visible per page
Permissions	AEM users, groups and ACLs; mandatory (read-only) actions per group	Site and org permissions in the Document Authoring config
Skills needed	AEM developer (Maven, JCR, OSGi) plus AEM admin	Site admin editing config sheets; no developer needed
Infrastructure	AEM Sites as a Cloud Service author environment and Cloud Manager	Document Authoring and Edge Delivery only; no AEM author environment

4. Setup comparison

AEM MSM (option A) 1. Build the language masters in AEM Sites. 2. Deploy the blueprint configuration, rollout configurations and OSGi settings through Cloud Manager. 3. Create the live copies with Create Site or Create Live Copy. 4. For each live copy root, create an Edge Delivery site with the shared code repository, and map its path in `public.json`. 5. Configure the cloud configuration per localized site (Configuration Browser and page properties). 6. Authors roll out and synchronize; publishing sends content to each Edge Delivery site.

A ready-to-deploy file set for this option is in `aem-msm/`.

Experience Workspace MSM (option B) 1. Create the base site and the satellite sites. All of them share the same code repository. 2. In each site's configuration, set the Edge Delivery content provider to use the MSM endpoint. 3. Add an `msm` tab to the org config at `da.live/config#/<org>/`, listing the base and its satellites. 4. Enable the MSM actions through the `prepare` tab and, optionally, the MSM app through the `apps` tab. 5. Authors detach pages that need local changes, and reconnect them to restore inheritance. 6. Base authors push preview/publish to satellites; satellite authors sync with Merge or Replace.

5. Strengths and limits

AEM MSM - + Fine-grained control: component and property inheritance, exclusions, ordered actions. - + Automatic link rewriting and event-based triggers. - + Works for Content Fragments and Assets as well as pages. - – Needs AEM authoring, developers and a Cloud Manager deployment for every config change. - – On Modification triggers can slow authoring; reset and detach need careful governance.

Experience Workspace MSM - + No code; configured in minutes through sheets. - + Unchanged pages need no copy at all: satellites read them from the base. - + Fits the Document Authoring workflow this site already uses. - – Inheritance is all-or-nothing per page; one local change detaches the whole page. - – Merge depends on the page structure matching; very different pages need manual review. - – No triggers, exclusions or custom sync actions.

6. Which one to choose

Choose **AEM MSM** when…	Choose **Experience Workspace MSM** when…
Content is already authored in AEM Sites, or must be	Content is authored in Document Authoring (this project)
Local teams change parts of pages but must keep the rest inherited	Local teams either keep a page as it is or own the whole page
You need automatic triggers, link rewriting or read-only global content	Manual push and sync by authors is enough
Content Fragments or Assets must be reused across sites	Reuse is mainly pages
An AEM development team is available	No developer should be needed for multi-site setup

7. Recommendation for this project

- **Stay on Document Authoring and use Experience Workspace MSM**, unless the business needs component-level inheritance or AEM-only content types.
- A possible structure using the locales in the current navigation:
  - Base site `edsmsm` with the language folders `/us/en` (and others created with the Translate app).

    - Satellite sites per market (for example Canada, Switzerland) that inherit from the base and detach only market-specific pages.
- Keep internal links relative so inherited pages work on every site.
- Move to option A only if the requirements in section 6 apply. The prepared `aem-msm/` files then become relevant.

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8. Sources

- PDF: *AEM Multi Site Manager (MSM) — Comprehensive Feature Guide* (21 Oct 2026)
- aem.live: Multi-Site Manager (Experience Workspace) – `/docs/ew/administering/multi-site-manager`
- aem.live: Repoless Multisite Manager (AEM authoring) – `/developer/repoless-multisite-manager`
- aem.live: Repoless – `/docs/repoless`
- aem.live: Translation, Translation strategy, Translation projects – `/docs/ew/administering/translation`, `/docs/ew/administering/translation-strategy`, `/docs/ew/authoring/translation-projects`
- Experience League: Reusing Content – Multi Site Manager and Live Copy (AEM as a Cloud Service)

Experience Workspace features change quickly. Check the current aem.live documentation before relying on a specific feature.